

ARTIST AND INVENTOR Born 1452 Died 1519

Leonardo da Vinci

“All our **knowledge** has its origins in our perceptions.”

LEONARDO DA VINCI

One of the great geniuses of the Italian Renaissance (see pp.250–53), Leonardo was the illegitimate son of a peasant woman; his father married a Florentine heiress eight months after his birth. Raised in the countryside outside Florence, he received little formal education, and only learned Latin, the basic accomplishment of an educated man of his day, in adulthood. Instead, he studied the animals and landscapes around him. It was characteristic of Leonardo that, at a time when artists and philosophers were fixated on learning from the classical past, he concentrated on direct observation of the human and natural world.

It is possible to present Leonardo's career as that of an ambitious artisan and entrepreneur, a poor boy making

good use of opportunities for profit and advancement. He had the good fortune to be born near Florence, home to the finest concentration of painters, sculptors, and architects in 15th-century Europe. At about age 14, he was apprenticed to Andrea del Verrocchio, a leading sculptor whose studio had recently branched out into painting. Leonardo's outstanding talent, especially in the relatively new medium of oil painting, was unmistakable, and in his mid-20s he was able to set up a studio of his own.

Leonardo's paintings are now his most famous achievement, but in the 15th century, even with his own studio, an artist was only a craftsman touting for commissions.

The next step up was to be taken on by a prince as a member of his household. Thus, in about 1482, Leonardo proposed his services to Ludovico Sforza, the ruler of

Ducal commission

This document from Cesare Borgia, lord of the Romagna, dates to 1502, commissioned “architect and engineer” Leonardo to survey palaces and fortresses.



Florence Cathedral
During his apprenticeship in Florence, Leonardo helped place the orb and cross on top of the city's famous cathedral dome.

di Leonardo da Vinci

Self-portrait

Leonardo drew this haunting self-portrait when he was in his mid-60s, three or four years before his death. The long hair and beard give him the air of a traditional sage or seer.